

Nora: Exploring a Feminist Approach to VR Creation

Weixuan Huang*

Key Laboratory of Intelligent Dramatic Arts Space of
Ministry of Education, The Central Academy of Drama
Beijing, China
weixuanhuang@chntheatre.edu.cn

Jingjing Guo*

Key Laboratory of Intelligent Dramatic Arts Space of
Ministry of Education, The Central Academy of Drama
Beijing, China
jingjingguo@chntheatre.edu.cn

Yi Shi*

Key Laboratory of Intelligent Dramatic Arts Space of
Ministry of Education, The Central Academy of Drama
Beijing, China
yishi@chntheatre.edu.cn

Shan Wang†

Key Laboratory of Intelligent Dramatic Arts Space of
Ministry of Education, The Central Academy of Drama
Beijing, China
wangshan@zhongxi.cn



Figure 1: Participants use VR equipment to experience *Nora*.

Abstract

The development of innovative virtual reality (VR) methodologies represents a critical imperative in an era where VR reconfigures human perception and facilitates complex cultural expression. This paper explores the intersection of feminism and VR creation, presenting an interactive narrative experience. "*Nora*" recounts the

*These authors contributed equally to this research.

†Corresponding author.

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story of "Na", a rural woman's journey of self-growth. Guided by feminist theory, the work is innovatively designed in terms of content, perspective, and interactivity. Additionally, user feedback was analyzed to inform future improvements. "*Nora*" explores how feminist theory influences various aspects of VR creation and provides new insights into the transformative role of feminism in VR artistic practice.

CCS Concepts

• **Human-centered computing** → *Human computer interaction (HCI); Interaction paradigms; Virtual reality*; • **Applied computing** → *Arts and humanities; Media arts*; • **Social and professional topics** → *User characteristics; Gender; Women*.

Keywords

Virtual Reality, Interactive narratives, Third-person perspective, Feminism

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1 Introduction

The phenomenon of systemic othering of women conceptualized by Simone de Beauvoir [de Beauvoir 1949] persists in the contemporary digital realm, where technology reshapes cognitive boundaries and compounds the challenges of feminist narratives. This marginalization was manifested in the default male-centric user paradigm of head-mounted displays (HMDs) [Grassini and Laumann 2020], interaction mechanisms that insufficiently accounted for women's embodied experience [Lee 2022], and gender-stereotyped virtual identity templates [Zhang and Juvrud 2024]. Therefore, integrating feminist perspectives into VR creation offers the potential to challenge and partly reduce the "otherness" of women in the virtual world.

In this context, *Nora* provides an innovative VR interactive narrative based on feminism (Fig. 1). Inspired by the real Chinese news story "*Nora on the Plain*" (2021) [An 2021] and Ibsen's "*A Doll's House*" (1879) [Ibsen 1879], the work tells the story of a rural woman "Na" who resists family constraints and realizes her self-worth. Guided by feminist theory, we innovated in storyline design and VR scene construction, third-person perspective switching mechanisms, and interactive systems that matched the narrative perspective.

2 Related Work

Among seminal gender-focused VR works, *A Walk Alone* [Al-Zubeidi et al. 2021] informed our approach to spatial empathy through nocturnal walking simulation. *FIGHT BACK ORIGINS* [Blondiaux and Tricart 2025] demonstrates VR's potential for resistance training. *HerVerse* [Fang 2025]'s glitch aesthetics reinforces our critique of gendered representation, while *Second War Zone* [Gasworks 2016]'s deconstruction of Male Gaze motivated our perspective-switching mechanism.

Narrative perspective fundamentally shapes storytelling [Prince 2012]. VR expands this dimensionality [Kambe and Nakajima 2022], requiring users to distinguish the self from the character for empathy, a principle central to our dual-perspective design. First-person works like *She Was Here* [Yu 2018] and *Dear Angelica* [Unsel 2017] demonstrate how first-person VR can foster emotional immersion, while Holzapfel's [Holzapfel 2014] theory on third-person perspectives revealing gendered power structures directly guided our innovation. Successful precedents such as *Wolves in the Walls* [Billington and Shamash 2018] and *The Book of Distance* [National Film Board of Canada 2020] illustrate the feasibility of this framework.

3 Design

3.1 Content

In the process of creating *Nora*, content and plot design form the core foundation. The narrative was inspired by the true story "*Nora on the Plain*" and Ibsen's play "*A Doll's House*". "*Nora on the Plain*"

depicts the life of a rural Chinese woman who taught herself Mandarin through television and books despite severe material constraints. She chose to run away but eventually returned home for various practical reasons. Her declaration that "I would rather suffer than be numb" resonated on Chinese social media. "*A Doll's House*" depicts *Nora's* awakening: treated as a doll by her husband, she chooses to escape after realizing her subordinate status in marriage and challenges the social value of women with her actions. This cross-era, cross-cultural dialogue constitutes the feminist narrative framework we constructed.

The distinction between "Na" and "Nora" is intentional. One of the main reasons we chose "*Nora*" as the title of the artwork is that Na's story can be seen as a possible continuation of the narrative after *Nora's* departure in "*A Doll's House*". Their juxtaposition establishes a cross-cultural dialogue, which underscores the universality of women's struggles for autonomy while also preserving the specificity of local conditions.

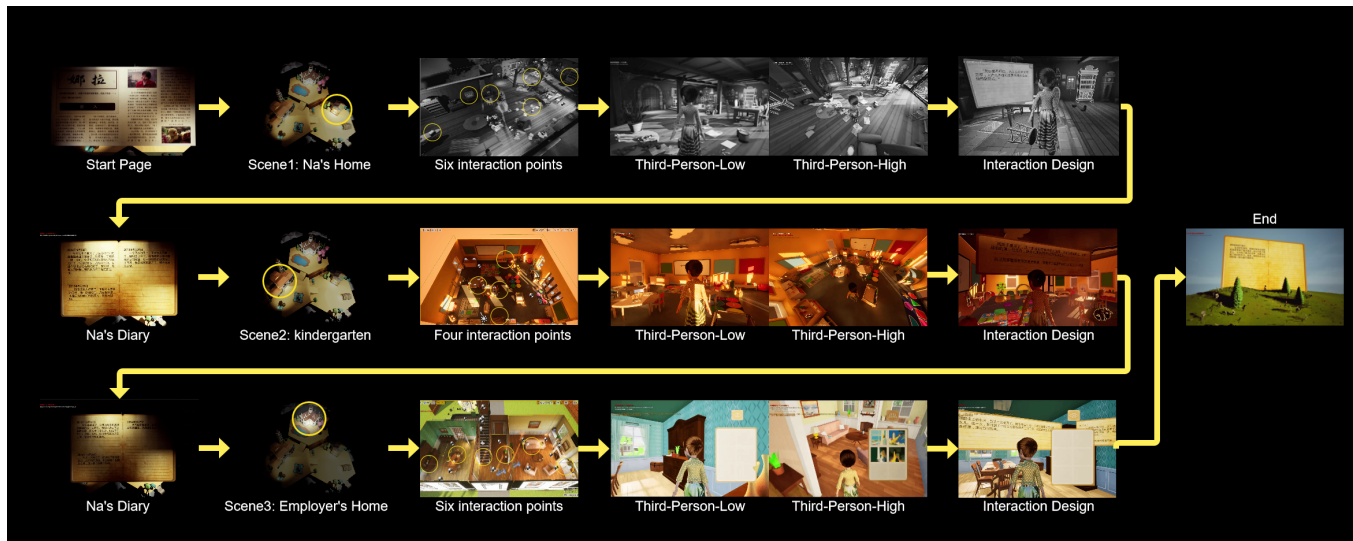
Nora's content reflects Na's cyclical resistance to spatial confinement. Her journey oscillates between attempted escapes from domestic oppression and compelled returns due to socioeconomic constraints, a pattern reminiscent of the real-life narrative documented in "*Nora on the Plain*". Each departure intensifies her feminist consciousness. Ultimately, she enacts *Nora's* iconic departure, achieving decisive liberation. The story content revolves around a sandbox scene and three indoor spaces, each with independent storylines. Upon completing scene interactions, the system guides users to exit through doors, triggering sandbox transitions and diary animations that summarize narrative content (Fig. 2).

Among them, the design of the diary part is of great importance. As a "female self-discourse", women's survival experience can only be transformed into effective knowledge of social cognition through public narrative [Scott 1991], which underscores the value of using diaries as public narrative clues. Users can follow the diary animation in the sandbox scene to switch to the next indoor scene. The narrative line of the indoor scene and the narrative content in the diary are intertwined (Fig. 3), forming a comprehensive story context.

3.2 Perspective

The user's perspective determines how users understand the story. However, visual fluidity can deconstruct fixed character identities [Butler 1990]. To highlight the advantages of the third-person perspective and explore how different third-person perspectives enhance the feminist interactive narrative experience in VR, this work designs two perspectives: Third-Person High and Third-Person Low (Fig. 4) [Ulrichs et al. 2024], enabling users to switch freely between them. In Unreal Engine, cameras for both perspectives are set up, with the left controller's trigger key designated as the switch button.

In the Third-Person High Perspective, the camera is 1.4 meters from the character and 2.4 meters high, equipped with a 20mm wide-angle lens enabling an overview of the entire scene and all interactive situations. The Third-Person Low Perspective functions as a follow-up view: the camera is 1.4 meters from the character and 1.5 meters high, using a 35mm wide-angle lens. This perspective

Figure 2: Storyboard of *Nora*.

Scene	Summary	Diary
	Na's Home: "Welcome to Na's Home. Feel free to explore, learn Na's story, and help with household tasks."	September 13, 2013 Autumn seems to be approaching, yet I've grown numb to the passage of time. Every day feels like a carbon copy of the last. I told Wang Gai today that I wanted to find work outside. He remained silent, which surprised me. This thought has lingered for a while. I know no one would stop me—I simply can't bring myself to leave this life behind.
	Kindergarten: "Na's first job as a childcare worker. Please help take care of the children."	October 11, 2013 Autumn has finally arrived. The autumn here turns out to be no different from back home. I've gradually adapted to this place—the principal is rarely around, and spending time with the children brings me peace. I think I truly enjoy this job. How good it feels to have the freedom of choice.
	Na's Home: "Na has returned home. Please continue with the household chores."	January 29, 2014 The weather is getting colder and colder, and the New Year is almost here. I have to go home. May 9, 2015 The cicadas' cries are irritating. Every day feels the same—exhausting and numb. I've decided to make a change.
	Employer's Home: "Na found part-time work as a housekeeper in the city. The lady of the house is a picture book author. Please collect her works within this space."	September 5, 2015 After Tiantian started middle school, I left home once again. I feel fortunate to have such an obedient, sensible, and supportive daughter. This time, I've found part-time work as a housekeeper in the city. The lady of the house is a picture book author who treats me with genuine kindness.
	Grassland: "Na walks into the distance. Vast grasslands, shining sun, a free wind blows past."	September 10, 2016 Life goes on. Sometimes I feel my choices have brought more pain; I've encountered more people, encountered a larger world, and become more aware of my own powerlessness. But even now, I don't feel regret, because I'm no longer numb.

Figure 3: Narrative lines of major scenes and diary contents.

allows users to experience the scene from a closer vantage point, enhancing their ability to engage with scene details.

By designing switches between the two third-person perspectives, this work seeks to echo Male Gaze theory. In classic Hollywood cinema, the spectator's gaze is often encoded as male, positioning women as objects of viewing [Mulvey 2006]. This theory has since been extended to other fields, including literature and digital art. In studies [Moi 2006] of *A Doll's House*, Ibsen's attempt to introduce dual viewing perspectives is noted, allowing users to choose between them and identify with Nora's situation through Mrs. Linde's perspective. We metaphorically address the social dynamics of women's objectification via perspective switching:

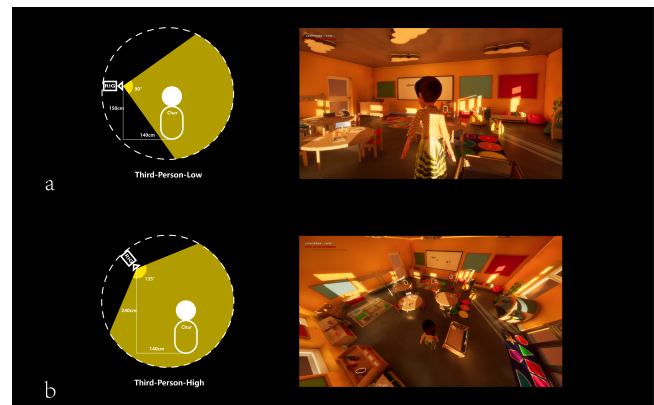


Figure 4: Design of the Third-Person-Low Perspective and Actual Screenshots in UE (a). Camera Design of the Third-Person-High Perspective and Actual Screenshots in UE (b).

the Third-Person Low Perspective highlights the everyday experience of "being gazed at", while the Third-Person High Perspective metaphorically represents Panopticon Structural Oppression [Foucault 1995]. This work attempts to explore the potential of feminist narrative in VR through innovative perspective design.

3.3 Interaction

In the field of VR, interaction is crucial. It not only drives narrative development but also enhances immersion. Our design further emphasizes spatial interaction, treating the arrangement of objects and paths as central to shaping user experience.

In *Nora*, the spatial placement of interactive objects—such as books, clothes, and televisions—and the paths required to trigger them are designed to echo women's everyday struggles. These details guide users to notice experiences that are often overlooked in



Figure 5: Interactive design of kindergarten scenes.

broader narratives. (Fig. 5) This focus on material details also resonates with feminist art practices, where objects serve as witnesses to women's creativity [Chicago 1974] or embody contradictions in women's maternal identity transformation [Kelly 1979]. To reinforce this connection, *Nora* highlights items tied to the protagonist's daily life; for example, approaching a book triggers a pop-up window: "Na doesn't play cards or go out, but she reads everything during housework breaks." Such objects align with feminist material culture research [Oakley 2018], where everyday items, as metaphorical carriers of gender power, encode experiences that dominant narratives often obscure [Irigaray 1974].

The interactive process is structured in stages: users can switch perspectives to better observe the space, interact with objects along a designed narrative path, and trigger narrative cues from these objects to progress through the story. This combined design of perspective and interaction repositions the user's power, thereby prompting reflection on who holds agency in the environment and how it is negotiated through interaction.

In *Nora*, interaction does not alter narrative direction. This work focuses on immersing users in the designed narrative, encouraging them to reflect on Na's choices and explore object-based clues, making the female voice visible and audible. By leveraging the third-person perspective's environmental storytelling capacity, the interaction design integrates seamlessly with scene exploration. Interactive object details deepen narrative understanding and user experience, enabling full story comprehension through scene exploration and interaction completion.

4 User Study

We recruited 14 adult participants (7 males and 7 females) aged 22 to 37, to experience our VR work and provide feedback.

Most participants recognized the feminist narrative intention of the story: "I was touched by the feminist spirit in this story." Na's struggle illustrates women's plight and offers her unique response. "In such an environment, it is difficult for women to make changes... I think she is very brave." This confirms our core goal: to resonate women's stories with the audience through content design. The perspective switching design was highly praised for its novelty, serving as both an interactive enhancer and emotional amplifier. "I used the third-person-high perspective for item-searching but relied

on the third-person-low perspective most, immersing in Na's view-point." While not all users grasped the male gaze metaphor, they acknowledged, "I am not just a bystander."

We identified areas for improvement and future optimization: text density and speed compromised immersion, and the UI requires refinement. Users' demand for a "more satisfying ending" highlights the potential of branching narratives. This demand signifies deeper resonance, reflecting societal aspirations for empowering women's narratives. It suggests users seek not only narrative closure but also invest in envisioning diverse, fulfilling trajectories for female characters, specifically those characterized by agency, autonomy, and multifaceted potential.

5 Conclusion

This paper focuses on the intersection of feminist theory and VR creation. Guided by feminist theory, *Nora* embodies its innovative approach through three key aspects. First, Na's story is based on real Chinese news reports and classic Western scripts, presenting cross-cultural feminist parallels and distinctions. This offers a unique cultural perspective for VR narrative. Second, the work incorporates Male Gaze theory through two switchable third-person perspectives that dynamically adjust to user interactions. Third, objects embodying women's lived experiences serve as the narrative core. Collectively, these elements create a distinctive VR interactive experience. For future optimization, we will refine *Nora* based on user feedback: enhancing text pacing and UI, developing branching narratives, and expanding perspective-switching mechanics to deepen the critique of gendered gaze and further promote feminist-guided VR creation.

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